

1-lakh rupee projectors, and this is amazing considering this one is present in a lower category. It did very well in *F.E.A.R* thanks to its ability to work with very dark scenes easily and with great detail (a healthy contrast ratio at work here), but we felt there was room for improvement in *Crysis*. The environments looked lovely and so were the effects, but somehow, the NEC VT800 in particular, makes such scenes look much more lifelike, crisp, and the foliage and outdoors look so much more resplendent. To be fair, at Rs 49,000, the XR-30X is nearly half the NEC VT800's price, and for half a lakh rupees, this is the best performing projector we've seen by yards.

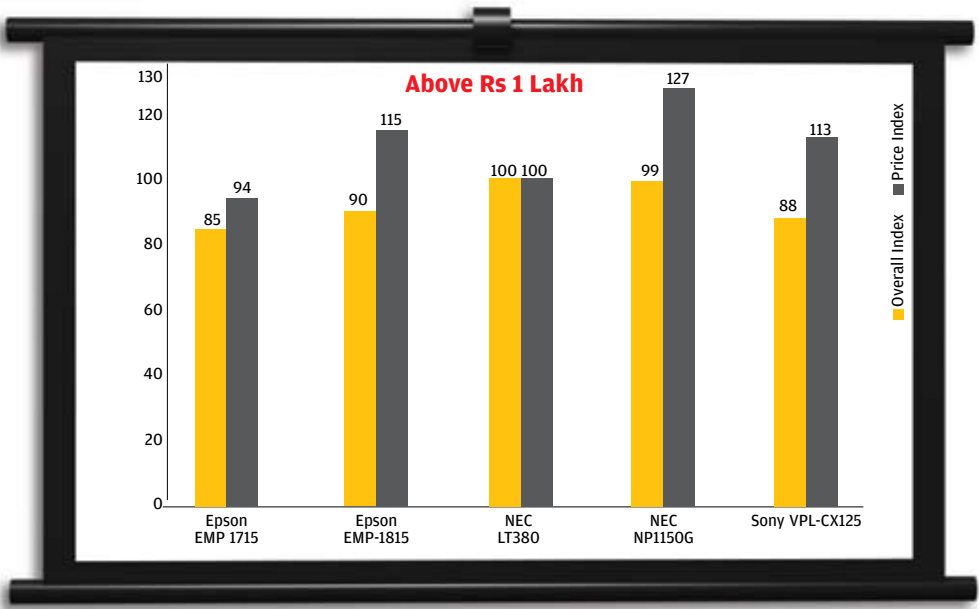
Above 1 Lakh
Going To The Movies Will Be Cheaper, But Not As Much Fun

Epson EMP 1715

The EMP 1715 is the smaller alternative to the EMP 1815 and much lighter and compact than its larger sibling. It sports a superb finish and an even better build quality, something we expected from a device in this price category, but it's good to see products live up to their pedigree. At first glance, it seems like a business oriented device with its boxy looks, and the inclusion of wireless LAN and USB connectivity reiterate this fact. RJ45 is missed, as is the inclusion of a card reader, which the elder sibling sports. A shutter system hides and protects the lens and acts as an A/V mute system when closed. It has a small, fat remote



Epson EMP 1715



unit that works very well. It has a wide angle of functionality from the front and the rear, better than the other projectors in test. We fired up DisplayMate first. After calibration, a deficient contrast ratio was noticeable. It performed well in the geometry tests and the reverse text tests. Text, although readable, has smudgy, blurry edges, that we didn't like. Although not usually an issue for a multimedia projector, a device aimed at the corporate world, should do well at any sort of text test. Colour quality is quite good with excellent rendition of reds and greens, crisp, vibrant and normal saturation. Although nearly all the mid-range and high-end NEC models do better, we have no complaints.

In our movie tests, we noticed some minor issues with contrast. Other issues existed with clarity of the picture, although brightness and detail levels were quite good. One thing to note about the EMP 1715 is that

it doesn't like to work with content that is non-native in terms of resolution. Most projectors don't, but the problem was a little more noticeable with this model. This was most obvious in our gaming and movie tests, due to which gamers and movie junkies may steer clear of this model. At Rs 1,16,600, this projector is certainly expensive enough, not to have such nagging issues! It's clearly a business oriented device. The problem that we have with this, is that a much cheaper model—the XR-30X from Sharp, outperforms it in the text and presentation tests, of importance to corporates, which is why Epson doesn't earn a recommendation from us here.

Epson EMP 1815

Another boxy looking projector and one that immediately fits the corporate image. It's very well built, and the materials used are top class, although the finish is somewhat uninspiring if not downright unattractive. A large footprint means you better make some serious room for this projector. With both WiFi and RJ45 connectivity, and the inclusion of a Compact Flash (CF) memory slot, the EMP 1815 is very much a corporate projector. USB 'A' and 'B' type connects are also provided. Once again, like its



Epson EMP 1815

smaller sibling the lens protector doubles as an A/V on-off switch. DisplayMate showed some issues with resolution, not a good sign for such a high-end projector, although the rest of the tests passed uneventfully. Text wasn't as sharp as we'd like it to be, and this is our major gripe with a corporate product—at least perform in the realm of your expertise for heaven's sake! The same issue the EMP 1715 had crops up here—problems when working with non-native resolutions. Movie junkies and gamers will probably stop reading this review here and jump ahead. Nevertheless, there was also the presence of phase disturbances and *moiré* in the horizontal and vertical bar and line tests to contend with. Thankfully, it has a good contrast ratio. The movie and game tests were pretty much identical in terms of

results to its alternative (the EMP 1715) and for this price, all gamers will jump ship. For Rs 1,42,000, the Epson 1815 is a large projector that does quite a few things well, some decently, and fails to deliver on one or two fronts. At this price point, however, it's perfection you're after, and you won't find it here.

Sony VPL-CX125

A very large and bulky projector to look at, with a superb finish—dark grey looks classy and suave and the quality of materials used by Sony is top class. It's got a large remote control unit that's equally well built and works wonderfully well. For such a high-end device, we bemoan the lack of DVI and component connectivity. Even USB connects have been shockingly omitted, although RJ45 connectivity is present. Also, this device doesn't have any WiFi capabili-

ties, so corporates who use such connectivity options will need to look elsewhere. The menu system with its very slick and ultra usable 4-way joystick is a pleasure to use. In fact, both the options and the ability to control them is so seamless, it's like an iPod Touch as far as human interfacing goes. The VPL-CX125 handled DisplayMate rather well and besides the presence of some *moiré* and issues with colour shifting, the *White Shift* and *Black Shift* part of the tests, this projector did rather well. It scores well when working with text, and the reverse text performance was also good. No surprise, that photographs look clear and crisp on this projector, ditto presentations. We also enjoyed the movie tests. It does hold its own in any sort of video playback test. In gaming, *F.E.A.R* did well as expected, although there were slight flaws with the contrast and detailing at lower light intensities. In *Crysis* we couldn't spot any flaws. Note that while some NEC projectors did a better job, the VPL-CX 125 isn't bad at gaming. This projector is therefore suitable for multimedia use, but at Rs 1,39,900, the question of investing such a large sum for mediocre performance raises its ugly head. There are better performing, cheaper projectors out there—no offence to the VPL-CX125's great capabilities.

NEC LT380

One of the best looking projectors in test, the LT380, has a rounded, contoured body finished in a satin smooth material with an attractive off-white colour. The front part that houses the lens, protrudes outwards in a curvy manner, giving this projec-

How We Tested

We divided our lot of projectors on the basis of prices:
1. Up to Rs 50,000
2. Rs 50,000 to Rs 1 Lakh
3. Above Rs 1 Lakh

Features

Here we looked at the basic features that anyone would expect a projector to have. All its specifications are noted by us, but we don't rate them, as they reflect in the performance scores. We did rate features like the presence of optical zoom, and the connectivity options were graded. We gave a lot of importance to the menu layout, as some of you may have to frequently tune your projector for different usage patterns such as movie watching, text presentations, Internet surfing and gaming.

Performance

We calibrated these projectors using DisplayMate Video Edition. After calibrating, we ran Display Mate's own suite through

Test Rig Configuration

Processor	Intel Core 2 Duo E6700
Motherboard	Gigabyte P965 DQ6
RAM	Kingston 3GB DDR2 800 MHz
Graphics Card	NVIDIA GeForce 8800GTX
OS	Windows XP Professional SP3

them to test various parameters. For our text and presentation tests, we used MS Word and PowerPoint 2007. For our movie tests, we used at least ten different clips, half of which were native 720p and the others were 1080p clips. We also used two DVD movies. For our gaming tests, we used three games, although we only rated two of them—*Crysis* and *F.E.A.R.* to avoid making the test game heavy. The third game we used was *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.*, because it mixes gloomy outdoors with some great environment effects.